

to access those rights by helping adults obtain their national identity cards and register as voters. In addition, the women's village committees provide a forum for women to be actively involved in community development, thus fostering gender equality within the community.

The PCDP's adult education syllabus is rights-based and addresses a range of issues relevant to the community, with reading and discussion questions for encouraging participatory problem solving. By encouraging girls and women to attend school and adult education classes and by ensuring that the curriculum materials show gender balance, the PCDP's Multilingual Education (MLE) programme actively promotes equal rights for women. Likewise, the story track for children specifically includes positive role models of women in the community. Similarly, training women in midwifery, basic health, handicrafts, and tailoring demonstrates that women can have professional and business roles within the community.

Such activities have led to a change in mentality among the Parkari community. Until recently, Parkaris in the desert used to be regularly harassed by the local police force or the army. For example, members of the army or police sometimes march up to villagers and demand a chicken or a goat. Although they have no right to make such demands from any citizens, illiterate Parkaris, unaware of their human and civic rights and fearful of offending anyone in authority, would simply give them what they demanded. In this way the government forces, employed for protecting all citizens, defraud the Parkari of the little livelihood they possess.

Monika Thollefsen is born in 1981. She has a master in Comparative and International Education from the University of Oslo. Monika lived in Madagascar from 2009 to 2011 where she worked at the Teacher Training College, SFM, in Fandriana for one year as an FK participant. From 2010–2011 she worked for the Norwegian Mission Society as a pedagogical advisor in the Green Education Programme. (Monika is currently working for the Norwegian directorate for education and training.)

Cuba and education

The chapter is based on field data gathered during a research visit to Cuba in 2005 and 2012 and from literature in the field. Conducting field-work in Cuba is not without problems, and in many ways more difficult than field-work that I have conducted in African countries like South Africa and Sudan. The reason for this is the tight ideological control that the Cuban government wants to keep over its visiting researchers. The institute we were attached to, *Instituto Pedagógico Latinoamericano y Caribeño in Havana*, gave us, besides all the necessary policy documents on education used in our documentary analysis, a list of schools in which we could do research and visit. To a certain extent, this restricted our movements and the variety of schools examined, but we also managed to visit schools not planned for in advance. The impressions from those schools did not, however, deviate much from the schools visited in the official program. We interviewed students, teachers, professors, government officials, and informed citizens. Besides interviews we also observed teaching and teaching methods in the schools.

The good reputation of Cuba's education system

While Cuba is a Latin-American country structured by a common history of colonialism and resistance, neo-colonialism and poverty, Cuba's education system is reputed to be among the best in the region, if not in the Southern hemisphere. Not even the most ardent critics of the Cuban political system can deny its impressive record since the inception of the revolution. As James Wolfensohn, the former president of the World Bank, stated in 2001:

Cuba has done a great job in education and health ... I have no hesitation in acknowledging that they've done a good job, and it doesn't embarrass me to do it ... We just have nothing to do with them in the present sense, and they should be congratulated on what they've done (Red Feather Institute, 2001)

Wolfensohn was right, neither the World Bank nor the IMF has given a cent to Cuba since the revolution in 1959.

The education system in Cuba is famous for its focus on inclusion and equality of opportunity, but also for its focus on political and ideological conformity. What is important in the context of this chapter is to explore the reasons why Cuba's education system is so well reputed. Moreover, the chapter explores to what extent the Cuban education system is influenced by what is often called the global architecture of education, i.e. a common, educational discourse based on Western ideas which dominates most education systems both in the global South as well as in the North (see also Breidlid, 2013). The question is thus if Cubans experience the strong influence of Western educational ideas like that witnessed in most parts of the global South, or whether Castro has managed to impress a Cuban, if not indigenous, imprint on the educational discourse in the country.

The Cuban education system's reputation for quality education and equality of opportunity impels the question: how is this possible in a nation with huge economic problems, not the least due to the embargo imposed by the USA for fifty years. Cuba's apparent success story seems to undermine the conventional wisdom that only well-functioning countries in the global North can provide quality education for the majority of their students.

Education for all

An important principle for Cuba is education for all. It is however acknowledged, even by some top-ranking people in the education system, that the concern with quality, one of the official reasons for embarking on the new transformation, has not been prioritized sufficiently due to the great quantitative demands. One challenge is that some rural areas might not be able to provide the same quality education as in Havana. Another is that access was, and still is not, necessarily the same for

blacks and whites. Many black families still live in poor housing and working conditions, and despite the political quest for equality and equity, marginality has not been done away with, as it still has a tendency to reproduce itself, albeit to a lesser degree than most countries in the Southern hemisphere.¹

This said, Cuba has probably succeeded more than any other country in the global South in making quality education available for its rural population (an expressed goal from the early days of the revolution). Moreover, the capital, Havana, has its own problems with the recruitment of good teachers due to the attraction of the tourist industry which emerged after the fall of the USSR.²

An impressive feature of the education system is how well organized it is, from the ministry to the classroom level. The reasons may undoubtedly be linked to the need of the regime to have complete ideological control; nevertheless, there is a lesson or two to be learned both by other countries in the global South as well as in the North.

The liberating power of education

There is in Cuba a strong belief in the liberating or even revolutionary power of education. Moreover, there is an equally strong belief in promoting a specific educational discourse at the expense of other discourses. Even though the Cuban education system is linked to Marxism (due to its close connection with the USSR until the 1990s) the education system is nevertheless situated in a context of Cubanization and nationalism, thus preventing an undifferentiated and uncritical import of educational ideas from the West, i.e. the import of the ideology of the global architecture of education referred to above. Besides Fidel Castro, the dominant or hegemonic educational ideas in Cuba are influenced in particular by the two heroes and martyrs, Jose Marti, and Che Guevara (see Breidlid, 2007). Based on Marti's statement that "No social equality is possible without equality of education and culture," education in Cuba reflects the communist and egalitarian orientation of Fidel

1. Rit que eaqum, ommo quibus atiam nonsequam eum cumenim et as rae de plis estius as quam, imus, acipsapere nest, sum rae consenda doluptas verero idus aut pa dolor rerae.

2. Giti optaspicatur sit et incitis quiamusapere et eum, eos eossequas maxima doluptaectem verrovid minimus.

Castro's regime. Moreover, as Noah W. Sobe and Renee N. Timberlake (2010) assert, Martí's position has risen significantly in the recent years, possibly to reinforce a national and authentic character of Cuban education. When the children, before the beginning of the school day, pay allegiance to the Cuban flag, they venerate Che Guevara by reciting the following slogan of the Young pioneers: "*Seremos como Che*" ("We will be like Che").

A strong streak of moralism and idealism also permeates the schools, with Che Guevara's vision of "the new man" as a focal point. Guevara argued for the importance of creating a new, radical consciousness among the people and the adoption of moral rather than material incentives.

Conscientization and consciousness through education were the fundamental principles in Che Guevara's thinking, implying that "consciousness and education were primary in the study of relations of production in the transitional economy, including the construction of communism" (Martinez, 2005). While the role given to conscientization and education and his reversion of the role of base and superstructure was a fundamental deviation from Marxism, Che Guevara's focus on solidarity and communitarianism was not.

Che Guevara's focus on conscientization and education as the primary agent of change is reminiscent of Freire's ideas of conscientization, but departs in important ways from the philosophy of the Brazilian educationist. Freire suggests that every human being is a repository of knowledges, not an "empty vessel" devoid of knowledges, and he has valuable experiential knowledge to be applied in problem-posing dialogues, also non-Western indigenous knowledges (Freire, 1998).

While consciousness is an important word in Che Guevara's political and economic vocabulary there is little, if any, interrogation of Western hegemonic knowledge production. Moreover, Che Guevara seems to suggest that the answers are given and that no "real" dialogue is needed or permitted.

According to many of our informants, different opinions and views were/are, at least in theory, accepted in classroom discussions. It was, however, underlined that non-conformist views had to be very well argued, probably giving the teacher an easy task in imposing "consensus," that is, teaching in agreement with official policies. Clearly

there was and is, as Tom G. Griffiths (2009) states, a "consistent, overt politicization of schooling, with some key curricular and pedagogical reforms to drive the socialist formation of the new generations" (p. 51).

The twin relationship between the country's educational discourse and hegemonic political discourse is of course not a unique Cuban phenomenon. However, one of the most problematic aspects of the Cuban system is the forceful imposition of the hegemonic discourse, leaving almost no space for alternative discourses. The existence of the Internet illustrates the need for the regime to exercise hegemonic control. While the official explanation why the Internet is not accessible to the common man is because it is too costly, regulations prevent even those with money to get access. The Internet is used in some higher institutions of learning, like universities, etc., and in various other institutions and companies, but regular Internet use from home is basically restricted to foreigners or to Cubans with the right political affiliation.

Education and religion

Cuba was officially an atheist state from the victory of the revolution in 1959 until 1992 when atheism (and thus Marxist-Leninism) as a state creed was abolished. The deletion of Marxist-Leninism from the constitution and the visit of the popes in 1999 and in 2012 have eased the situation somewhat for religious students and teachers. According to one of our informants, a dissident: "I do not belong to the Catholic church, but it is quite clear that the Catholic church represents the only alternative institution to the current Cuban government, and has on many occasions entered negotiations with the government to release prisoners and ease political oppression. The Catholic church is doing a fabulous job under very difficult circumstances (2012).

Neither Christian religion nor the Santería, a blend of native African religions and Roman Catholicism, is, however, part of the curriculum, but according to some of our informants atheism is not being taught. Religious believers are tolerated in the schools, and Mormons are, for instance, not forced to pay allegiance to the flag as the vast majority of schoolchildren do every morning.

Christians can now become members of the Communist Party and the Santería religion is now being promoted to attract tourists to the island.